‘Lalaji himself is a great man. He travels by the first or the second class. How would he know the people who travel in the third class?’ Indeed, ‘[h]ow would he know who endures kicks in the third class waiting rooms?’.

In fact, Lala Lajpat Rai’s distance from his people is only made worse when ‘[h]e sits in the motor car and passes through thousands of villages, laughing and joking with his friends’. Given this, ‘how would we know what thousands of people go through’.[9] For this reason, it is not leaders like Lala Lajpat Rai, but the youth of India like Bhagat Singh, who understand the plight of their people because ‘[w]hen we see the peasants work in the heat, cold rain, sun, hot-low winds and foggy day and night’ and notice how ‘these poor people make do with dry crumbs – and are burdened by debt’, one has to ask, ‘[d]on’t we burn with agony? Does not a fire rage in our hearts’[10] What is needed are ‘new ideas in this new environment’.[11] All this emphasized how Bhagat Singh’s revolution was intended to be a revolution of ideas. Lala Lajpat Rai’s stance in this respect would only replace one form of tyranny with another. This is why Bhagat Singh asks the rhetorical question: ‘Does Lalaji want that now we should rebel against the English rulers and hand over the reins in the hands of the rich?’[12]

To his abiding regret, Bhagat Singh laments the fact that ‘Lala Lajpat Rai has, for some reason, from the very beginning been against the youth movements’. This is surprising, because like Bhagat Singh, ‘[h]e imbibed his idea of patriotism from the great Giuseppe Mazzini of Italy’, and ironically, ‘Mazzini was a great admirer of the youth’ for ‘their voice carries magic’.[13] It would appear that one reason why Lala Lajpat Rai did not trust the youth was because of the events of 1907, when the young Ajit Singh made a fiery speech at Lyallpur. That had resulted in both him and Lala Lajpat Rai being subject to a sentence of deportation. This is why ‘Lalaji expounds that people should be wary of the movements led by the hot-headed youth of today’, but as Bhagat Singh asks, ‘Why dig up the past of 1907-08?’[14]

In fact, such criticism of the youth was not always justified because Bhagat Singh used the pen much more than the sword. This is where his